

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Reason, Revelation and Faith - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 32 diagnostics, 11 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Reason, Revelation and Faith - Solved Practice Workbook

Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · Topic 05 A standalone practice document. It is designed to be worked without the learning session open beside it, and it repeats no teaching prose.

How to use this workbook

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** using a length-balanced, non-patterned assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; **the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

What is inside

Part	Content	Count
1	Core diagnostic MCQs	24
2	Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
-	Question-specific option explanations	128
-	Unique examiner traps	32
3	Verified previous-year questions, fully solved	11
4	Original solved Mains models (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)	6

Marking and timing conventions

- Word bands: 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words.
- Every model answer follows **claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification**.
- Every model answer closes with a decided verdict, and the twenty-mark models additionally name the **defeater** that would change that verdict.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** using a length-balanced, non-patterned assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and the four positions each carry exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. Regulative rather than constitutive reason

Reason is said to be *regulative* rather than *constitutive* of religious belief. Which statement states that claim most exactly?

- A. Reason converts religious commitment into demonstrative knowledge of its object.
- B. Reason becomes relevant only once a doctrine has been accepted as infallible.
- C. Reason vetoes contradiction and disciplines interpretation without authoring content.
- D. Reason deduces every revealed mystery from premises that are self-evident.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Conversion into demonstration is exactly what Aquinas denies of faith, which has firmness without vision; this option describes knowledge, not regulation.
- **B:** Incorrect: Deferring reason until after infallibility has been granted removes its veto, which is the one power the regulative model insists on retaining.
- **C:** Correct: Regulation is the negative and corrective power to veto incoherence, weigh testimony, discipline reading and name defeaters, while constitution would be the productive power to supply content.
- **D:** Incorrect: Deducing the mysteries from self-evident premises is constitutive rationalism, the position the regulative model is defined against.

Examiner trap 1: The 2021 stem prints the word "regulative"; scripts that answer with "reason and faith are both important" have not engaged the printed term at all.

MCQ 2. The two axes of revelation are independent

Consider the following statements about the two axes of revelation. (i) The general/special distinction concerns scope and medium. (ii) The propositional/non-propositional distinction concerns what revelation is. (iii) The two distinctions are two names for one ladder. Which are correct?

- A. (i) and (iii) only
- B. (i) and (ii) only
- C. (ii) and (iii) only
- D. (i), (ii) and (iii)

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Statement (iii) is the error the owner explicitly warns against, so any combination that includes it must be rejected.
- **B:** Correct: Scope and medium form one axis, and the nature of revelation as truth-content or as encounter forms a second, independent axis that crosses it.
- **C:** Incorrect: Statement (ii) is right but (iii) is wrong, so this pairing imports the collapse the distinction is designed to prevent.
- **D:** Incorrect: Accepting all three is self-contradictory, since (iii) denies the independence that (i) and (ii) jointly assert.

Examiner trap 2: Collapsing scope into nature makes the 2025 fifteen-marker unanswerable, because natural and revealed theology are then indistinguishable from general and special revelation.

MCQ 3. Where Aquinas locates the act of faith

For Aquinas, faith is best located as which of the following?

- A. A probable opinion that still retains the fear that the opposite may be true.
- B. An emotional condition that operates entirely independently of the intellect.
- C. Firm intellectual assent to unseen divine truth, commanded by the will under grace.
- D. Demonstrative knowledge of the mysteries derived from purely natural premises.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Opinion is precisely what faith is *not*: opinion lacks firmness, whereas faith assents firmly.
- **B:** Incorrect: Aquinas makes faith an act of the intellect; removing the intellect destroys the account he actually gives.
- **C:** Correct: Faith is the intellect's firm assent to divine truth, commanded by the will moved by grace, and it is a mean between knowledge, which has sight, and opinion, which does not have firmness.
- **D:** Incorrect: If the mysteries were demonstrable from natural premises they would be preambles, and the two-storey structure would collapse.

Examiner trap 3: "Certainty without evidence" is the wrong gloss. It is firmness without *vision*, resting on testimony and motives of credibility.

MCQ 4. Hick's four-step chain, in order

Which sequence correctly states Hick's non-propositional model of revelation?

- A. Infallible scripture, then deductive proof, then divine action, then private feeling.
- B. Ambiguous event, then faith's experiencing-as, then communal interpretation, then doctrine.
- C. Linguistic analysis, then elimination of experience, then delivery of revealed propositions.
- D. Natural theology, then scientific confirmation, then doctrine, then religious encounter.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: This reverses the model: it begins with the propositions Hick treats as the community's later interpretation.
- **B:** Correct: Events are religiously ambiguous, faith perceives them as divine action, communities conceptualise the encounter, and doctrinal diversity then reflects interpretive schemes.
- **C:** Incorrect: Elimination of experience belongs to the verificationist debate owned by the religious-language clause, not to Hick's account of revelation.
- **D:** Incorrect: Making scientific confirmation a step in revelation misdescribes both natural theology and the non-propositional model.

Examiner trap 4: "Experiencing-as" is a perceptual structure under a concept, not a synonym for an intense feeling.

MCQ 5. Matching an authentication test to its limit

Which pairing of an authentication test with its correct built-in limit is accurate?

- A. Coherence - a fully coherent claim is thereby shown to be of divine origin.
- B. Moral fruit - beneficial effects are impossible under a false belief system.
- C. Tradition - long communal endurance is by itself a direct proof of truth.
- D. Testimony - a report can transmit error just as reliably as it transmits truth.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Coherence cannot establish divine origin; a consistent fiction remains consistent, which is exactly the stated limit.
- **B:** Incorrect: The owner states the opposite: useful effects can occur under false beliefs, which is why fruit is defeasible evidence.
- **C:** Incorrect: Communal endurance may preserve power or bias rather than truth, so endurance is not proof.
- **D:** Correct: Testimony's limit is precisely that it transmits error as well as truth, which is why witness competence, sincerity, placement and independent support all have to be assessed.

Examiner trap 5: Listing the six tests without their limits forfeits the analytical marks in the 2024 fifteen-marker, where the stem asks for your own comments.

MCQ 6. The two printed deliverables of the 2020 stem

In the 2020 fifteen-mark stem, "What are the basic tenets of faith? Distinguish between faith and belief", the structurally correct response is to:

- A. Enumerate the tenets first, then run the differentia table between faith and belief.
- B. Define faith as belief without evidence and then contrast it with scientific belief.
- C. Discuss Aquinas at length and treat the tenets as an implied conclusion.
- D. Present the faith-belief distinction only, since the tenets follow from it automatically.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: The stem prints two separate deliverables, and the owner's decoder requires enumeration of the seven tenets followed by a differentia table.
- **B:** Incorrect: Defining faith as evidence-free belief makes the second half of the stem unanswerable and is a listed trap.
- **C:** Incorrect: Aquinas supports the distinction through the faith which is believed and the faith by which one believes, but he is evidence, not the structure.
- **D:** Incorrect: Deriving the tenets from the distinction inverts the printed order and leaves the first deliverable unaddressed.

Examiner trap 6: Two printed obligations mean two visible sections. An examiner scanning for the tenets should not have to hunt for them inside a comparison.

MCQ 7. Mīmāṃsā's authorless scripture

Which statement most precisely captures Mīmāṃsā's position on scriptural authority?

- A. The Veda is the speech of a creator God and is authenticated by miracles.
- B. The Veda derives its authority from Nyāya-style inference to a reliable speaker.
- C. Mīmāṃsā rejects the authority of the Veda in favour of perception alone.
- D. The Veda is authorless, so it has authority without any revealer, human or divine.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Attributing the Veda to a creator God's speech destroys the very feature that makes the comparison valuable.
- **B:** Incorrect: Inference to a reliable speaker is the Nyāya route; Mīmāṃsā's authorless doctrine is designed to avoid needing one.
- **C:** Incorrect: Rejecting scriptural authority in favour of perception alone is the Cārvāka position, not the Mīmāṃsā position.
- **D:** Correct: The authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda is authoritative without an author, which is why India offers a form of scriptural authority with no revealer.

Examiner trap 7: This is a listed trap in the owner. Calling the authorless Veda "revelation from a personal God" reverses the one point the comparison exists to make.

MCQ 8. The exact analogue of proper basicity

Which is the closest classical Indian analogue of Plantinga's proper basicity?

- A. Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity, on which a cognition is valid until it is defeated.
- B. Nyāya's extrinsic validity, on which validity must be established by something further.
- C. Cārvāka's restriction of the means of knowledge to perception alone.
- D. The Advaita triad of hearing, reasoning and assimilation taken as a whole.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) holds a cognition valid on its own until defeated, which is structurally what proper basicity claims.
- **B:** Incorrect: Extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) requires further certification, so it is the analogue of evidentialism, not of proper basicity.
- **C:** Incorrect: Cārvāka's restriction to perception is the strict evidentialist limit case at the far end of the same spectrum.
- **D:** Incorrect: The pedagogic triad describes a route from scripture to realisation; it is not a theory of when a cognition counts as valid.

Examiner trap 8: The owner forbids a looser parallel. Write the exact pair - intrinsic validity with proper basicity, extrinsic validity with evidentialism.

MCQ 9. The load-bearing step against evidentialism

Which statement correctly describes the load-bearing step in Plantinga's argument against the evidentialist objection?

- A. He shows by demonstration that God exists and therefore that belief is warranted.
- B. He argues classical foundationalism is self-referentially incoherent and too narrow.
- C. He claims that the proposition "God exists" is self-evident to any rational person.
- D. He denies that religious belief can ever be defeated by any counter-consideration.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Plantinga's argument is epistemological and does not run through a demonstration of God's existence.
- **B:** Correct: The criterion of classical foundationalism satisfies none of its own conditions and cannot accommodate memory, other minds or beliefs about the past, so basicity is not confined to its list.
- **C:** Incorrect: Self-evidence is precisely what Plantinga does *not* claim; that is a listed trap in the owner file.
- **D:** Incorrect: He insists on defeasibility, naming evil, projection theories and cognitive-science explanations as potential defeaters.

Examiner trap 9: Do not write that Plantinga makes God's existence self-evident. He makes theistic belief properly basic, grounded, warranted and defeasible.

MCQ 10. What restricts James's will-to-believe

Which of the following states the restriction that keeps James's will-to-believe from licensing wishful thinking?

- A. The belief must be endorsed by an established religious community before adoption.
- B. The believer must show that the belief produces measurable psychological benefit.
- C. The proposition must first be shown probable on the balance of available evidence.
- D. The option must be living, forced and momentous, with evidence genuinely inconclusive.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Communal endorsement is a criterion in the authentication debate, not James's restriction.
- **B:** Incorrect: Measurable benefit is closer to a fruit test; James's restriction is about the structure of the option.
- **C:** Incorrect: If the proposition could be shown probable, evidence would decide and the passionate decision would be unnecessary.
- **D:** Correct: The permission applies only to a living, forced and momentous option where the evidence is genuinely inconclusive, and it never licenses belief against evidence.

Examiner trap 10: Quoting Clifford without James, or James without the three conditions, is the standard way to lose the analytical mark in a justification question.

MCQ 11. What Hume's argument actually concludes

Which statement about Hume's argument in "Of Miracles" is accurate?

- A. He demonstrates that divine action upon the natural order is metaphysically impossible.
- B. He argues that testimony faces an evidential burden it cannot ordinarily discharge.
- C. He accepts any report supported by witnesses of good moral character.
- D. He treats miracles as coincidences that observers subsequently misdescribe.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Hume's conclusion concerns the force of testimony, not the metaphysical possibility of divine action, and treating it otherwise is a listed trap.
- **B:** Correct: Part I sets uniform experience against non-uniform testimony and issues the maxim that testimony suffices only if its falsehood would be more miraculous than the reported fact.
- **C:** Incorrect: Good character is only one of the four Part II considerations, and Hume denies that any actual case has satisfied the full set.
- **D:** Incorrect: Hume defines a miracle as a violation of a law of nature by a particular divine volition, not as a misdescribed coincidence.

Examiner trap 11: Hume raised the bar; he did not prove it unclearable. Say so, then bring in Swinburne's redefinition and Earman's Bayesian objection.

MCQ 12. Why Swinburne redefines a miracle

Swinburne's recasting of "miracle" as a non-repeatable counter-instance is deployed in order to:

- A. Show that Hume's definition of a miracle as a law-violation is itself contestable.
- B. Prove that at least one miracle report in history has been conclusively established.
- C. Demonstrate that laws of nature admit no exceptions of any description whatever.
- D. Replace testimony with direct perception as the sole ground of miracle-claims.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: If a law is an exceptionless regularity, a genuine exception shows the law was mis-stated, so the redefinition prevents miracles from being defined out of existence.
- **B:** Incorrect: The redefinition is conceptual; it establishes no particular historical report.
- **C:** Incorrect: The point is the reverse: it makes room for a non-repeatable exception to an otherwise well-confirmed law.
- **D:** Incorrect: Swinburne strengthens testimony through the principles of credulity and testimony rather than replacing it.

Examiner trap 12: Accepting Hume's definition without contest concedes the argument before it begins, because the definitional reply is available and cheap.

MCQ 13. Matching a Barbour model to its cost

Which pairing of a Barbour model with its stated cost is correct?

- A. Dialogue - it ties theology to the scientific theories of the present day.
- B. Integration - it forbids either domain to make claims the other could contest.
- C. Independence - it purchases peace by silencing both parties on contestable claims.
- D. Conflict - it establishes conversation but never reaches any firm conclusions.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Hostage-taking by current science is the cost of Integration, not of Dialogue.
- **B:** Incorrect: Enforced mutual silence is the cost of Independence, which is exactly what non-overlapping magisteria prescribes.
- **C:** Correct: Independence, of which Gould's non-overlapping magisteria is the named form, avoids conflict by forbidding either side to say anything the other could contest.
- **D:** Incorrect: Being fruitful but non-committal is the cost of Dialogue; Conflict's problem is that it overgeneralises from distorted history.

Examiner trap 13: Treating non-overlapping magisteria as the obvious solution loses marks. State the price it charges.

MCQ 14. The status of the Draper-White warfare thesis

Which statement about the Draper-White "warfare thesis" should appear in a strong 2020-type answer?

- A. It is the settled consensus among modern historians of science and needs no further comment.
- B. It was formulated in the mid-twentieth century as a direct response to logical positivism.
- C. It concerns only the Islamic and Indian traditions rather than the European material.
- D. It is now rejected by most historians of science as a polemical nineteenth-century construction.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: The owner records the opposite, and repeating the thesis uncritically is the characteristic weak-band move.
- **B:** Incorrect: The two works are dated 1874 and 1896 respectively, so the mid-twentieth-century framing is simply wrong.
- **C:** Incorrect: Draper's and White's books address the European and Christian material directly.
- **D:** Correct: Draper (1874) and White (1896) supply the historiography of the Conflict model, and its rejection by most historians of science is a mark-earning qualification rather than a digression.

Examiner trap 14: Narrating Galileo instead of using the typology is the single most common failure in this question.

MCQ 15. Supra-rational against irrational

Which formulation correctly distinguishes the supra-rational from the irrational?

- A. The supra-rational exceeds what proof establishes; the irrational contradicts coherence or decisive evidence.
- B. The supra-rational is a feeling; the irrational is a proposition that has been falsified by observation.
- C. The supra-rational applies to scripture; the irrational applies to unaided philosophical argument.
- D. The supra-rational is a weaker degree of the rational; the irrational is its complete absence.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Exceeding proof and contradicting reason are different relations, and this middle category is precisely what the 2023 fifteen-marker is buying.
- **B:** Incorrect: Reducing the supra-rational to feeling abandons the cognitive claim that makes it a third epistemic category.
- **C:** Incorrect: The distinction is about the relation of a claim to proof, not about the type of source it comes from.
- **D:** Incorrect: Treating it as a weaker rationality returns to the two-term scale the distinction exists to break.

Examiner trap 15: A two-column answer to the 2023 stem loses the question. The middle term is the answer.

MCQ 16. What separates natural from revealed theology

On the propositional model, the distinction between natural and revealed theology is fundamentally a distinction in:

- A. Religious importance, since revealed truths always matter more than natural ones.
- B. Emotional intensity, since revealed truths are received with greater fervour.
- C. Epistemic access, since the two differ in where their premises can be obtained.
- D. Historical period, since natural theology preceded revealed theology in time.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Importance is not the criterion; both theologies speak about God and both matter within the system.
- **B:** Incorrect: Intensity belongs to the phenomenology of religious experience, which the firewall assigns to another owner.
- **C:** Correct: Natural theology argues from publicly accessible premises, while revealed theology proceeds from premises the propositional model says could only be received through disclosure.
- **D:** Incorrect: No chronological priority is asserted; the distinction is systematic rather than developmental.

Examiner trap 16: Answering the 2025 stem with a two-column table that never mentions the propositional view drops the third printed term, which carries marks.

MCQ 17. Why circularity is not automatically fatal

Which statement best explains why the circularity objection to scriptural authority is not automatically fatal?

- A. Circularity is a formal fallacy only in mathematics, so it does not apply to theology.
- B. Divine authorship guarantees that the circle is closed in a way no critic can examine.
- C. Communities are entitled to accept their own founding documents without further inquiry.
- D. Many epistemic practices use reciprocal support; the issue is whether the circle is vicious.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Circularity is a defect wherever a conclusion is smuggled into its own support, and no discipline is exempt.
- **B:** Incorrect: Appealing to divine authorship to close the circle is precisely the move that makes the circle vicious.
- **C:** Incorrect: Entitlement without inquiry converts a defeasible warrant into insulated fideism.
- **D:** Correct: Reciprocal support is common in epistemology, so the live question is whether this circle is vicious or a coherent web, which turns on whether independent support enters it.

Examiner trap 17: State the criterion for viciousness - a circle that is the *only* support offered - or the reply looks like special pleading.

MCQ 18. The two-sided reading of the 2022 stem

Which reading of the 2022 stem, "Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation?", earns the highest marks?

- A. Faith is dispensable, since a propositional revelation is true whether or not it is received.
- B. Faith is indispensable for reception and efficacy, though not for objective occurrence.
- C. Faith is indispensable in every sense, since without faith no disclosure can occur at all.
- D. The question is unanswerable, since revelation and faith are defined in terms of each other.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: This concedes only the objective half and ignores the point that unreceived content is not revelation *for* a person.
- **B:** Correct: The answer holds both halves: divinely communicated content would be true unreceived, yet an event becomes revelation for someone only through the faith that recognises and accepts it.
- **C:** Incorrect: Making faith a condition of the disclosure's occurrence overstates the case and invites the propositional counter-example.
- **D:** Incorrect: Mutual definition is not established, and declaring the stem unanswerable forfeits the directive's demand for a critical comment.

Examiner trap 18: "Critically comment" at ten marks wants one distinction, one objection and one verdict - not a survey of revelation theories.

MCQ 19. Why natural theology is the narrower field

Which of the following is the strongest reason for treating natural theology as narrower than philosophy of religion?

- A. Philosophy of religion also analyses religious language, experience and warrant.
- B. Natural theology alone employs deductive reasoning about the divine nature.
- C. Philosophy of religion is confined to describing the beliefs of existing communities.
- D. Natural theology is a modern discipline whereas philosophy of religion is ancient.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Natural theology argues toward theological conclusions, while philosophy of religion has the wider analytical field of language, experience and warrant and may reach negative conclusions.
- **B:** Incorrect: Both fields use deductive reasoning, so the difference cannot lie there.
- **C:** Incorrect: Confining philosophy of religion to description would make it sociology rather than philosophy.
- **D:** Incorrect: No such chronological claim is made in the controlling sources, and it would not establish the difference in scope.

Examiner trap 19: In the 2024 ten-marker the marks sit in reason's testing, interpreting and defending functions, not only in its constructive one.

MCQ 20. Alston's parity of doxastic practices

Alston's argument from doxastic practices is best summarised as which of the following?

- A. Religious experience yields the same degree of certainty as ordinary sense perception.
- B. No doxastic practice, sense perception included, can be validated non-circularly.
- C. Religious practice is rational only when independently confirmed by natural theology.
- D. Doxastic practices are rational only where a community has publicly agreed on them.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Parity of epistemic situation is claimed, not parity of certainty.
- **B:** Correct: Since we rationally engage in practices that cannot be non-circularly validated, socially established religious practice is in the same epistemic boat, and engaging in it is practically rational absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable.
- **C:** Incorrect: Requiring confirmation by natural theology reinstates precisely the evidentialist demand Alston is answering.
- **D:** Incorrect: Public agreement features as social establishment, but agreement is not the ground of rationality in the argument.

Examiner trap 20: Alston is the bridge to the religious-experience owner; use him for the parity argument, not for the phenomenology of experience.

MCQ 21. Ordering the permissions from strictest to loosest

Which sequence correctly orders permissions from strictest to loosest?

- A. Insulated fideism, then critical rationalism, then strict evidentialism, then Pascal's wager.
- B. Pascal's wager, then evidentialism, then insulated fideism, then critical rationalism.
- C. Critical rationalism, then insulated fideism, then Pascal's wager, then evidentialism.
- D. Evidentialism, then critical rationalism, then James's will-to-believe, then insulated fideism.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: This begins at the loosest position and ends in the middle, inverting the requested ordering.
- **B:** Incorrect: Prudential permission is looser than the evidentialist demand, so it cannot come first.
- **C:** Incorrect: Insulated fideism is the loosest position available and cannot sit second.
- **D:** Correct: The demand for sufficient evidence is strictest, critical rationalism permits commitment under continuing criticism, James permits it for a narrowly specified option, and insulated fideism permits it without any check.

Examiner trap 21: Kierkegaard does not belong at the loose end. His claim concerns who must decide, not how much evidence may be dispensed with.

MCQ 22. What Kierkegaard actually denies

Which claim about Kierkegaard is defensible on the controlling sources?

- A. He argues that a religious claim is more credible in proportion as it is absurd.
- B. He holds that objective argument is irrelevant to every question, religious or not.
- C. He denies that an objective system can replace the individual's existential decision.
- D. He treats Abraham as a general model for suspending ethical obligations at will.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: The "because it is absurd" slogan is not a verified quotation from Tertullian and is not Kierkegaard's thesis either.
- **B:** Incorrect: His argument is about religious appropriation, not a general scepticism about objective reasoning.
- **C:** Correct: Faith is passionate commitment under objective uncertainty, and his attack is on the claim that an objective philosophical system can substitute for existential decision.
- **D:** Incorrect: Abraham dramatises the paradox as a limit-case; reading him as a general licence is the caricature the owner warns against.

Examiner trap 22: Always pair the Kierkegaard exposition with the disclaimer that he licenses neither contradiction nor irresponsibility.

MCQ 23. The Indian treatment of the marvellous

Which contrast between Western and Indian treatments of the marvellous is accurate?

- A. Western apologetics authenticates revelation by miracles; Indian systems largely decline it.
- B. Indian systems rest scriptural authority on miracles; Western apologetics rests it on inference.
- C. Both traditions treat extraordinary powers as the decisive test of a genuine disclosure.
- D. Neither tradition records extraordinary powers, so no comparison can be constructed.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 declares the accomplishments obstacles, the *Kevaddha Sutta* has the Buddha refuse displays as a means of conversion, and Mīmāṃsā's authorless Veda needs no miraculous authentication at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: This inverts the position: Mīmāṃsā's doctrine exists precisely so that no miraculous authentication is required.
- **C:** Incorrect: Only the Western apologetic tradition gives the marvellous that evidential role.
- **D:** Incorrect: Both traditions record such powers; the difference lies in the evidential use made of them.

Examiner trap 23: Present this as a contrast, not a parallel. Claiming an Indian parallel here misdescribes both sides.

MCQ 24. What lifts a script into the top band

A top-band script on this clause is distinguished above the "strong" band chiefly by which addition?

- A. A longer list of thinkers, arranged in chronological order of their publications.
- B. A more detailed narrative of the historical episodes linking science and religion.
- C. A discriminating distinction plus a statement of what would change the stated verdict.
- D. A larger number of Sanskrit and Pali terms supplied without their English glosses.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Additional names without discrimination do not move a script past the strong band.
- **B:** Incorrect: Historical narrative is what the owner's traps warn against, particularly in the science stem.
- **C:** Correct: The top band requires a discriminating distinction, such as the faith which is believed against the faith by which one believes, together with a statement of what would change the verdict.
- **D:** Incorrect: Untranslated terminology violates the English-first rule and adds no analytical value.

Examiner trap 24: The defeater sentence is the cheapest top-band marker available and should be the last thing cut under time pressure.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

MCQ 25. Remedial - 'faith is belief without any evidence'

A candidate writes: "Faith is belief without any evidence." Which correction is best?

- A. Faith is an emotion with no cognitive content and therefore no relation to evidence.
- B. Faith is trustful commitment beyond conclusive proof and remains answerable to defeaters.
- C. Faith is demonstrative knowledge and is therefore epistemically stronger than reason.
- D. Faith is a weaker degree of belief, differing from it only in the confidence attached.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Denying cognitive content contradicts tenet two, which requires assent to some content.
- **B:** Correct: The error conflates non-demonstrative assent with groundlessness; faith may be rationally supported, supra-rational in commitment, and still open to defeat.
- **C:** Incorrect: Faith lacks the demonstrative vision that knowledge has, so it cannot be the stronger of the two in that sense.
- **D:** Incorrect: A difference in degree is exactly what the failure-mode test refutes, since betrayal is not a species of falsehood.

Examiner trap 25: This definition also destroys the second half of the 2020 stem, because it makes faith and belief indistinguishable except by confidence.

MCQ 26. Remedial - 'Aquinas lets faith contradict reason'

A candidate writes: "Aquinas allows faith to contradict reason where the mystery demands it." Which correction is best?

- A. Genuine reason and revelation cannot conflict; apparent clash signals a defect in reasoning.
- B. Every revealed mystery can in principle be demonstrated once the right premises are found.
- C. Reason becomes unnecessary once a scripture accepted as authoritative is available.
- D. Faith is entitled to accept a logical contradiction when the doctrine is sufficiently important.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Both routes issue from God, so an apparent clash indicates a defect in the reasoning or in the interpretation, never a true contradiction in reality.
- **B:** Incorrect: Demonstrable mysteries would be preambles, which would collapse the two-storey structure.
- **C:** Incorrect: Reason retains the preambles, the coherence test, interpretation and apologetics, so it does not become redundant.
- **D:** Incorrect: Accepting a contradiction is the irrational, not the supra-rational; the distinction is precisely what Aquinas needs.

Examiner trap 26: Write "above reason, never against reason". Those five words are worth more than a paragraph of paraphrase.

MCQ 27. Remedial - revelation, inspiration and infallibility

A candidate writes: "Revelation, inspiration and infallibility all mean the same thing." Which correction is best?

- A. All three describe the same event under different denominational vocabularies.
- B. Revelation is the record, inspiration is the disclosure, and infallibility is the community's assent.
- C. Revelation is the disclosure, inspiration the authorship of the record, infallibility freedom from error.
- D. Only infallibility is a genuine notion; the other two are pre-critical descriptions of it.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: The owner states explicitly that the three are not interchangeable, so denominational vocabulary is not the issue.
- **B:** Incorrect: This misassigns each term; the record is not revelation, and infallibility is not communal assent.
- **C:** Correct: Disclosure, authorship of the record and freedom from error are three separable notions that can come apart.
- **D:** Incorrect: Reducing the set to infallibility loses the very distinction the propositional model depends on.

Examiner trap 27: These three terms can come apart in practice, and noticing that is a cheap discriminator in a revelation question.

MCQ 28. Remedial - 'Hume proved miracles impossible'

A candidate writes: "Hume proved that miracles are impossible." Which correction is best?

- A. Hume held that only reports from educated witnesses can establish an extraordinary event.
- B. Hume argued that testimony normally cannot overcome the evidence for natural regularities.
- C. Hume denied that laws of nature have any evidential standing in questions of this kind.
- D. Hume treated the four Part II considerations as a proof of divine non-intervention.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Witness quality is one Part II consideration, not the whole argument, and Hume denies any actual case satisfies the full set.
- **B:** Correct: The conclusion concerns the evidential force of testimony, and Swinburne and Earman both contest the strength of that bar.
- **C:** Incorrect: The argument depends on laws of nature having the strongest evidential standing available.
- **D:** Incorrect: Part II offers considerations of evidential caution, not a proof about divine action.

Examiner trap 28: State what survives - Part II as a checklist of caution - and what does not - Part I, which would exclude testimony for any sufficiently improbable event.

MCQ 29. Remedial - 'Plantinga says God's existence is self-evident'

A candidate writes: "Plantinga says God's existence is self-evident." Which correction is best?

- A. Plantinga rejects every cognitive faculty other than sense perception as a source of belief.
- B. Plantinga argues that theistic belief must be inferred from the design argument to be rational.
- C. Plantinga holds that religious belief is immune to criticism once it has been formed.
- D. Plantinga holds that theistic belief can be properly basic - grounded, warranted and defeasible.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: His proper-function account depends on a wider range of faculties, including a sense of the divine.
- **B:** Incorrect: Proper basicity is defined by *not* being inferred from other beliefs, so inference from design is beside the point.
- **C:** Incorrect: He insists on defeasibility and names evil, projection and cognitive-science explanations as potential defeaters.
- **D:** Correct: The claim is proper basicity with grounding, warrant through proper function, and openness to defeat, not self-evidence.

Examiner trap 29: "Properly basic" means non-inferred, not obvious. Those are different claims and the examiner is checking which one you hold.

MCQ 30. Remedial - narrating Galileo for the science stem

A candidate answers the 2020 science stem with a narrative of the Galileo affair. Which correction is best?

- A. Replace it with a narrative of the nineteenth-century evolution controversies instead.
- B. Replace it with an account of contemporary scientific consensus on cosmology.
- C. Replace it with Barbour's four models, each with its cost, and a domain-sensitive verdict.
- D. Replace it with a defence of non-overlapping magisteria as the settled solution.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Substituting one narrative for another repeats the same structural error.
- **B:** Incorrect: A survey of scientific results does not answer a question about the relation between two domains.
- **C:** Correct: The stem asks for significance vis-à-vis scientific and technological development, which is a relation and therefore calls for a typology with costs and a verdict.
- **D:** Incorrect: Non-overlapping magisteria is one model among four and carries the cost of enforced mutual silence.

Examiner trap 30: Add the normative point: technology settles what we can do, not what we should do, and not what a life is for.

MCQ 31. Remedial - trust (*śraddhā*) read as blind faith

A candidate writes that Indian trust (*śraddhā*) is simply the Indian word for blind faith. Which correction is best?

- A. Trust (*śraddhā*) denotes ritual correctness and has no epistemic dimension whatever.
- B. Trust (*śraddhā*) is exactly identical to the faith by which one believes in the scholastic sense.
- C. Trust (*śraddhā*) is a purely emotional attachment to a teacher with no cognitive role.
- D. Trust (*śraddhā*) is graded and verification-directed: it enables inquiry rather than replacing it.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Denying it any epistemic dimension contradicts its pedagogic role in initiating inquiry.
- **B:** Incorrect: The scholastic pair is a useful comparison, but identity would erase the graded typology of the *Gītā*.
- **C:** Incorrect: Reducing it to emotion loses precisely the feature that makes the Indian comparison valuable.
- **D:** Correct: The *Gītā* 17.2-3 grades it and makes it constitutive of the person, Advaita treats it as the trust that makes inquiry possible and is replaced by realisation, and the *Kālāma Sutta* directs Buddhist trust toward testing in experience.

Examiner trap 31: The comparative advantage is that Indian trust *initiates* verification, whereas Western faith often has to defend itself as trust that replaces it.

MCQ 32. Remedial - closing with 'both are important'

A candidate concludes a twenty-mark answer with "thus both reason and faith are important". Which correction is best?

- A. Replace it with a graded verdict that decides and names the defeater that would change it.
- B. Replace it with a longer restatement of the four stances already covered in the body.
- C. Replace it with a quotation from Tertullian on believing because the doctrine is absurd.
- D. Replace it with a declaration that the question cannot be settled by philosophical means.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Every directive in this clause rewards a decision, and the top band additionally requires a statement of what would change the verdict.
- **B:** Incorrect: Restating the body adds length without adding evaluation, which is what the verdict is for.
- **C:** Incorrect: That slogan is not a verified Tertullian quotation and should be used only as a later fideist label.
- **D:** Incorrect: Declaring the question un settleable abandons the directive rather than answering it.

Examiner trap 32: "Both are important" is the single most reliable way to cap a script in the average band, however good the preceding material.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified previous-year questions - 11 complete solutions

Word bands used throughout. 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words. Every question below is reproduced in its exact printed wording from the audited Philosophy of Religion previous-year ledger, 2018-2025. **The model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: What is instrumental to self-revelation: Faith or Reason? Justify your position.

Demand decoding: The directive is "justify your position" after an *either/or*. The examiner is buying a **choice**, defended - not "both matter". Choose, give the strongest case, then concede what the losing term explains better.

Model solution. Self-revelation is divine self-disclosure received by a subject. **Faith is the instrument of reception; reason is the instrument of regulation** - and reception is what the word *self-revelation* names.

Hick's non-propositional account settles the priority. An event is religiously ambiguous: the same occurrence bears a secular causal description and a providential one. What selects the religious reading is faith's "experiencing-as". Without that reception, the occurrence remains an occurrence and discloses no one. Kierkegaard makes the same point existentially: an objective system cannot be handed to a person in place of the appropriation only that person can perform.

Reason is nevertheless indispensable. It tests coherence, weighs testimony, disciplines interpretation and separates disclosure from delusion. In Advaita, trust (*śraddhā*) opens inquiry while reasoning (*manana*) removes doubt.

Objection: propositional content, if divinely communicated, is true whether or not it is received. **Reply:** conceded for the objective content - but unreceived content is not revelation *for* anyone.

Verdict: faith receives, reason disciplines. Faith is the more instrumental, though it is not self-validating.

Why this earns marks: it makes the required choice; it uses Hick, Kierkegaard and the Indian pair analytically rather than decoratively; it separates objective disclosure from subjective reception; and it closes with a directive-responsive verdict rather than a summary.

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the significance of 'Religion' vis-à-vis the present scientific and technological development.

Demand decoding: "Vis-à-vis" asks for a **relation**, and a relation is answered by a typology, never by a narrative. Do not tell the story of Galileo.

Model solution. The relation between religion and scientific-technological development is a set of models, not a single verdict. Barbour's fourfold typology supplies the map.

Conflict treats both as competing claims about one world, in the mirror-image forms of scientific materialism and scriptural literalism; its historiography is the Draper-White warfare thesis of 1874 and 1896, now rejected by most historians of science as a polemical construction. **Independence** - Gould's non-overlapping magisteria (*Rocks of Ages*, 1999) - assigns fact to science and ultimate meaning to religion, but buys peace by forbidding either side to say anything the other could contest. **Dialogue** engages boundary questions: why there is a universe, why it is intelligible, why the constants permit life. **Integration** attempts natural theology, theology of nature or process thought, and is hostage to current science.

Religion's continuing significance is normative and existential: technology settles what we *can* do, not what we *should* do, and not what a life is for. Vivekananda's claim that Vedānta is experience-grounded and so science-compatible belongs here - reported as a claim.

Verdict: dialogue at the boundary questions, with local conflict only where a religious claim is genuinely empirical.

Why this earns marks: all four models with their costs; the warfare-thesis and non-overlapping-magisteria qualifications; the normative argument instead of vague moralising; and a decided verdict.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: What are the basic tenets of faith? Distinguish between faith and belief.

Demand decoding: Two printed deliverables, in the printed order. Enumerate the tenets; then run the differentia. Answering only the second half forfeits roughly half the marks.

Model solution. Faith is a fiduciary and volitional relation to what is held ultimate; belief is propositional assent. Every faith carries beliefs; not every belief is faith.

The basic tenets are seven. (1) An **object** held ultimate. (2) **Assent** to some content - faith is never contentless feeling. (3) **Trust** exceeding the available evidence. (4) **Commitment** of the will, with consequent risk. (5) **Hope** oriented to a good not yet secured. (6) A **community** and tradition that transmits and disciplines it. (7) **Fruits** - a transformed pattern of life by which it is tested.

The distinction runs on six axes. *Object:* a proposition against a person or ultimate. *Grammar:* believing *that* against believing *in*. *Mode:* cognitive assent against assent plus entrusting. *Voluntariness:* belief is largely involuntary, whereas faith engages the will. *Failure-mode:* belief fails by falsehood, faith by betrayal. *Degrees:* confidence against fidelity.

Aquinas' pair supports this - the faith which is believed (*fides quae creditur*), and the faith by which one believes (*fides qua creditur*). Wilfred Cantwell Smith (*Faith and Belief*, 1979) shows "belief" narrowed to propositional assent only in modern usage; Tillich makes faith an ultimate concern, whose characteristic failure is idolatry rather than doubt; Buber's I-Thou cannot be reduced to I-It propositions. The *Gītā* 17.2-3 grades trust (*śraddhā*) and makes it constitutive of the person; Buddhist trust (Pali: *saddhā*) is verification-directed, as the *Kālāma Sutta* insists.

Objection: "believing in" reduces to believing that something exists and is trustworthy. **Reply:** one may believe a person reliable and still refuse to entrust anything; the entrusting is irreducible.

Verdict: faith is not a weaker belief but a different act, and the two come apart in both directions.

Why this earns marks: both printed deliverables in order; seven tenets and six axes; four named Western supports plus two Indian anchors; and the reductionist objection answered.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the role of reason and faith in religion. Can reason be a regulative force in the formulation of religious beliefs? Explain.

Demand decoding: Two tasks again, the second carrying the discriminating term. "Regulative" must be defined against "constitutive"; the whole answer turns on that pair.

Model solution. Reason and faith are not rivals for one office. **Reason can and should regulate religious belief; it is not thereby constitutive of the belief's distinctive content.**

Reason's role is fourfold. It constructs **natural theology** - Aquinas' preambles, Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara). It **tests coherence:** no appeal to mystery can make a contradiction true. It **interprets** scripture, distinguishing literal, analogical and historically conditioned senses. It **defends**, answering the objector. Its limit is that the proofs are inconclusive and the transcendent may *exceed* reason - exceed, not contradict.

Faith's role is different in kind. For Aquinas, faith is the intellect's firm assent to divine truth commanded by the will moved by grace: it has the firmness of knowledge without its vision, and stands as a mean between knowledge and opinion. Kierkegaard locates faith in passionate appropriation under objective uncertainty - his target is substitution, not evidence. The Augustinian-Anselmian *credo ut intelligam* mediates: faith begins the inquiry, understanding deepens it.

Now the printed question. *Regulative* reason constrains: it vetoes contradiction, weighs testimony, disciplines reading and identifies defeaters. *Constitutive* reason would generate the content itself. Regulation is negative and occasion-bound, constitution is productive, and the asymmetry is real: reason can rule out an incoherent doctrine of God without being able to produce the doctrine of the Trinity. Critical rationalism formalises the regulative seat - committed belief kept open to criticism - and Plantinga's insistence that properly basic belief remains **defeasible** shows even the anti-evidentialist accepting regulation.

Objection: a power of universal veto is sovereignty in disguise. **Reply:** a referee who can disallow a goal does not score it.

Verdict: reason is regulative but not constitutive. The regulation is genuine only while the veto can actually bite; a tradition that admits no possible defeater has abandoned regulation for insulated fideism, and that is the defeater which would change this verdict.

Why this earns marks: both tasks answered; the regulative/constitutive pair defined and then *used*; five named positions; and a closing statement of what would overturn the conclusion.

PYQ 5 - 2022, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation? Critically comment.

Demand decoding: "Critically comment" at ten marks wants one distinction, one objection and one verdict - not a survey of revelation theories.

Model solution. Revelation is divine self-disclosure, and a disclosure must be *received* to function as one. On Hick's non-propositional model an event is religiously ambiguous; faith's "experiencing-as" perceives it as divine action, the community then conceptualises it, and doctrine follows. Without that reception the event is only an event, disclosing nothing to anyone.

The decisive move is a **distinction**: between the objective occurrence or content of a disclosure, and revelation *for* a person. **Objection:** on the propositional model, divinely communicated truths are true whether or not anyone accepts them, so faith cannot be indispensable. **Reply:** conceded at the level of content - but unreceived information is not revelation in anyone's religious life. Faith is the indispensable subjective condition of revelation's recognition and efficacy, not of its objective existence.

Verdict: faith is indispensable to revelation's reception, not to its occurrence - and holding both halves is what the word "critically" is buying.

Why this earns marks: one distinction, one objection, one verdict, exactly as the directive specifies; Hick used structurally; and the propositional counter-example conceded rather than ignored.

PYQ 6 - 2023, Q5(b), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can religious beliefs be justified? Discuss.

Demand decoding: The question is about the **standard** of justification, not about whether God exists. Name the epistemology in the first sentence.

Model solution. The question asks what standard a religious belief must meet, not whether its object exists.

Evidentialism answers: proportion assent to the evidence. Locke ties assent to probability; Clifford's "The Ethics of Belief" (1877) makes it moral - it is wrong to believe anything upon insufficient evidence, as his shipowner does; Flew's presumption of atheism puts the burden on the affirmative claim. **James** (1896) replies that where an option is living, forced and momentous and evidence cannot decide, the passionate nature may lawfully choose - and that Clifford's rule itself expresses a preference for avoiding error over gaining truth.

Reformed epistemology goes further. Plantinga argues the objection presupposes classical foundationalism, which is self-referentially incoherent and cannot accommodate memory, other minds or the past; belief in God, formed in appropriate circumstances, can therefore be **properly basic** - grounded, warranted by properly functioning faculties, and **defeasible**. Alston adds that no doxastic practice, sense perception included, is non-circularly validated.

The Indian mapping is exact: Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) parallels proper basicity; Nyāya's extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) parallels evidentialism; Cārvāka is the strict limit.

Verdict: yes - but justification is internal to a doxastic practice, which relocates the real problem from evidential insufficiency to religious diversity.

Why this earns marks: the standard is named first; both camps are reconstructed with their strongest moves; the exact Indian analogues are used; and the verdict identifies the residual problem instead of restating the debate.

PYQ 7 - 2023, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the rational and irrational aspects of faith in the discourse of religion.

Demand decoding: The stem prints two categories; the answer requires **three**. Insert the supra-rational, or the question cannot be answered without convicting religion by definition.

Model solution. Faith is standardly described as rational or irrational. The discourse in fact requires three categories, and the middle one is the answer.

The rational aspect. Faith has grounds. Aquinas' *preambles* - that God exists, and some divine attributes - are held to be demonstrable, and *motives of credibility* make assent reasonable though not coercive. Faith carries cognitive content, is internally testable for coherence, and can be supported cumulatively by testimony, moral fruit and experience. Reason interprets its texts and defends it against objections.

The supra-rational aspect. Faith assents to what is not seen. For Aquinas it has the firmness of knowledge without the vision, so it is neither opinion nor demonstration. For Kierkegaard, commitment occurs under objective uncertainty, and no system can be substituted for appropriation. This exceeds proof; it does not contradict it. Indian trust (*śraddhā*), graded in the *Gītā* 17.2-3, similarly opens an inquiry it does not pre-empt, and Buddhist trust (Pali: *saddhā*) is explicitly directed toward testing in experience.

The irrational aspect. Faith becomes irrational when it asserts a contradiction, defies decisive evidence, or claims immunity from every possible defeater. The later slogan about believing "because it is absurd" - not a verified Tertullian quotation - marks that extreme. Fideist immunity licenses fanaticism, which is why critical rationalism keeps committed belief answerable to criticism.

Objection: the supra-rational is a face-saving relabelling of the irrational. **Reply:** the two differ in their logical relation to proof - exceeding is not contradicting - and the difference is testable, because a supra-rational belief accepts defeaters while an irrational one does not.

Verdict: faith is rational in its grounds, supra-rational in its assent, and irrational only when it purchases security by refusing correction.

Why this earns marks: the three-term structure; Aquinas and Kierkegaard reconstructed rather than named; the quotation flagged as unsafe; and a testable criterion separating the middle term from the third.

PYQ 8 - 2024, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the role of reason in religion.

Demand decoding: A short, structured enumeration with a limit. The marks sit in the functions beyond proof.

Model solution. Reason's religious work is fourfold, and it is not exhausted by the attempt to prove God's existence.

First, reason **constructs natural theology**: it argues from publicly accessible premises toward theological conclusions, as in Aquinas' preambles of faith and Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara). Natural theology is narrower than philosophy of religion, which additionally analyses language, experience and warrant.

Second, reason **tests coherence**. No appeal to mystery can make a contradiction true; a doctrine that cannot be stated without self-contradiction is not thereby profound.

Third, reason **interprets**. Scripture requires hermeneutics, and authority does not eliminate it: literal, analogical and historically conditioned senses have to be distinguished.

Fourth, reason **defends** - apologetics - and, correlatively, criticises: it identifies defeaters and checks fanaticism.

Its **limit** is that the proofs are inconclusive and the transcendent may exceed the reach of finite reason. Kant restricts speculative reason beyond possible experience; natural theologians reply that metaphysical inference concerns the conditions of experience rather than a further observed object.

Verdict: reason is best described as **regulative** - it constrains, tests and interprets - without being constitutive of the content that revelation claims to supply.

Why this earns marks: four functions with named illustrations, one genuine objection with its reply, and a verdict using the regulative/constitutive pair.

PYQ 9 - 2024, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: What kind of epistemic justifications are possible with regard to claims to revelation? Discuss with your own comments.

Demand decoding: Two obligations: a **typology** of possible justifications, then a **first-person ranking**. The "own comments" clause is not decorative.

Model solution. A revelation-claim can be justified only by convergent and defeasible criteria. Six are available, and each carries a built-in limit.

Source and testimony: is the witness competent, sincere, suitably placed and independently supported? *Limit:* testimony transmits error as well as truth. **Coherence:** does the claim contradict itself or secure knowledge? *Limit:* a consistent fiction is still consistent, so coherence cannot establish divine origin. **Moral and spiritual fruit:** does reception produce truthfulness, compassion and transformation? *Limit:* useful effects can occur under false beliefs. **Tradition and community:** has the interpretation been publicly transmitted, criticised and corrected? *Limit:* communal endurance may preserve power or bias. **Experience and miracle-sign:** is there an event resistant to ordinary explanation and appropriately connected to the message? *Limit:* an unusual occurrence does not by itself authenticate one interpretation of it - Hume's Part II remains a standing checklist. **Cross-revelation comparison:** how does the claim answer rival disclosures? *Limit:* the criteria are rarely neutral between traditions.

Two structural problems cut across all six. **Circularity:** scripture authenticates God and God authorises scripture. That circle is vicious if it is the *only* support offered, and arguably virtuous if independent testimony, coherence and moral fruit enter it - many epistemic practices use reciprocal support. **Competing revelation:** rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims; distinguishing a core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation answers this, but critics fairly call the move revisionary.

My own ranking. Coherence is necessary but weakest, because it is merely negative. Cross-revelation comparison is the most demanding and therefore the most informative. Moral fruit and communal transmission are jointly stronger than either alone. The miracle-sign is the least useful, since it presupposes the interpretive framework it is meant to establish.

Verdict: warrant here is convergent, graded and defeasible - never demonstrative - and the residual difficulty is diversity rather than evidential poverty.

Why this earns marks: a complete typology with limits, both structural problems handled, and an explicit personal ranking as the stem demands.

PYQ 10 - 2025, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact verified question: How does Aquinas' account of Faith as "an intellectual assent" reconcile the juxtaposition between Reason and Faith? Discuss.

Demand decoding: "How does X reconcile A and B?" buys the **mechanism**, stated as a structure. Name the two storeys and the hinge.

Model solution. Aquinas reconciles reason and faith by architecture rather than compromise.

The act. Faith is an act of the *intellect* assenting to divine truth, commanded by the *will* moved by *grace* (*Summa Theologiae* II-II, qq. 1-4). Because revealed truth exceeds demonstrative sight, testimony supplies the object; because the evidence is non-coercive, the will commands assent; because the person must be oriented to divine truth, grace moves the will.

The location. Faith is a **mean**: it has the firmness of knowledge without knowledge's vision, and it lacks opinion's residual fear that the opposite is true. It borrows firmness from the one and unseenness from the other, and so is identical with neither.

The reconciliation. Reason establishes the **preambles** - that God exists. Revelation supplies the **mysteries** - for example the Trinity - which are *above* reason, never *against* it. Since both routes issue from God, they cannot genuinely conflict; an apparent conflict indicates defective reasoning or defective interpretation. The hinge is the *motives of credibility*, which make the assent reasonable though not demonstrative.

Objection: will-governed assent risks voluntarism. **Reply:** the will operates only where evidence is genuinely non-coercive, and the preambles plus the motives of credibility keep it from arbitrariness.

Verdict: the juxtaposition dissolves because reason and faith were never competing for the same office.

Why this earns marks: the mechanism is stated as a structure; the three-way location is used, not merely mentioned; and voluntarism - the standing objection - is answered.

PYQ 11 - 2025, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Distinguish between Natural Theology and Revealed Theology in the context of the Propositional view of Revelation.

Demand decoding: A **three-term** answer. "In the context of the propositional view" is a working constraint, not decoration: the propositional model is what makes the pair clean.

Model solution. On the propositional model, revelation communicates divinely authorised **truths** that unaided reason could not discover or securely know. That model is the frame within which the two theologies separate.

Natural theology argues from publicly accessible premises toward theological conclusions. Its content is what reason alone can reach - paradigmatically that God exists, and some divine attributes. Aquinas calls these the *preambles of faith*. Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara) is a non-Western instance of the same enterprise. Natural theology is narrower than philosophy of religion, which also analyses religious language, experience and warrant.

Revealed theology proceeds from premises taken to be delivered. On the propositional view its content is the **mysteries** - the Trinity, the Incarnation - articulated as doctrine from a disclosure mediated by prophets, scripture or tradition, and warranted by signs, testimony and coherence.

The distinction is one of epistemic access, not of importance or of rationality. Both speak about God; both reason; they differ in where the premises originate. Three further terms must not be merged: revelation is the disclosure, **inspiration** concerns the divine-human authorship of the record, and **infallibility** concerns freedom from error.

Two controls. First, the distinction is stable only under the propositional model: on Hick's non-propositional account, doctrine is the community's interpretation of an encounter, so the boundary blurs. Second, Mīmāṃsā complicates the Western picture productively - its authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda supplies scriptural authority with **no** revealer at all, showing that propositional scriptural authority and divine dictation are separable.

Objection: rival revelations and circular authentication weaken revealed theology's claim. **Reply:** its defenders appeal to cumulative criteria - coherence, moral fruit, testimony and transformative power - without pretending these are tradition-neutral.

Verdict: natural and revealed theology are two routes to one subject matter, distinguished by access; the propositional frame is what keeps them distinct, and abandoning that frame dissolves the distinction rather than refuting it.

Why this earns marks: all three printed terms are used; the access criterion is stated explicitly; the revelation/inspiration/infallibility trio is separated; and the Indian material does argumentative work.

Original solved Mains practice - 6 models

These are **original** questions written for practice; they are not previous-year questions. Word bands are as declared above.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question. Can reason authenticate a revelation-claim without circularity? Comment.

Model answer. Authentication asks why *this* alleged disclosure should be credited. The circularity charge is that scripture authenticates God while God authorises scripture, so the support never leaves the circle.

Reason can break the closure by importing independent lines. Coherence testing is external to the claim's own authority; testimony can be assessed for competence, sincerity, placement and corroboration; moral and spiritual fruit is observable independently of the doctrine; and comparison with rival disclosures is a test the tradition does not set for itself. Each is defeasible, and none establishes divine origin on its own.

The honest position is therefore a criterion for viciousness: a circle is vicious when it is the *only* support offered, and tolerable when independent evidence enters it. Many epistemic practices - including sense perception, as Alston notes - use reciprocal support without being dismissed.

Verdict: reason cannot authenticate a revelation-claim demonstratively, but it can convert a closed circle into a defeasible web. What would change this verdict is a tradition that refuses every external test.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question. "Faith that admits no possible defeater has purchased safety at the price of philosophical standing." Examine.

Model answer. The statement identifies the cost of insulation. A belief immune to every possible consideration cannot be assessed, compared or corrected; it has left the epistemic conversation to avoid losing an argument within it.

The claim is supported from both directions. Plantinga, the strongest defender of non-inferential religious belief, insists that properly basic theistic belief is **defeasible** - evil, projection theories and cognitive-science explanations are defeaters that must be met. Critical rationalism makes the same concession the price of committed belief. Aquinas retains the coherence test and the motives of credibility, so even his supra-rational assent is answerable.

Against the statement, it may be urged that some commitments are constitutive of a form of life and cannot be tested from outside without distortion.

Verdict: the statement is sound as stated. Faith may exceed proof without forfeiting standing; it forfeits standing when it claims exemption. The defeater would be a demonstration that no belief whatever is assessable from outside its own practice - a scepticism that would take sense perception with it.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question. Assess the claim that Indian epistemology supplies a genuine alternative, rather than a parallel, to Western accounts of revelation.

Model answer. The claim is partly true, and the parts must be separated.

Where India supplies a genuine alternative. Mīmāṃsā holds the Veda to be **authorless** (*apauruṣeya*). Scriptural authority therefore exists with no author, human or divine. That is not a variant of the Western model; it removes the revealer whose credibility the Western debate is organised around, and with it the need for miraculous authentication. Correspondingly, the Indian tradition largely **declines** the miracle strategy: *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 treats the accomplishments (*siddhi*) as obstacles to absorption, and the *Kevaddha Sutta* has the Buddha refuse displays of psychic power as a means of conversion. This is a contrast, not a parallel.

Where India supplies an exact parallel. The validity dispute maps precisely: Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) - a cognition is valid until defeated - parallels proper basicity; Nyāya's extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) parallels evidentialism; Cārvāka is the strict evidentialist limit.

Where the difference is one of emphasis. Trust (*śraddhā*) is verification-directed: it initiates inquiry and is replaced by realisation, whereas Western faith often defends itself as trust that substitutes for verification. The Advaita route - hearing (*śravaṇa*), reasoning (*manana*), assimilation (*nididhyāsana*) - makes reasoning auxiliary but indispensable.

Objection: the mappings distort, since proper basicity carries a design-plan theory and intrinsic validity belongs to a ritual hermeneutics. **Reply:** the parallel is claimed at the level of warrant-structure only.

Verdict: on the source of scriptural authority India is a genuine alternative; on the structure of validity it is an exact parallel. Conflating the two is what makes comparative answers look decorative.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question. "The evidentialist objection to religious belief is self-defeating." Critically discuss.

Model answer. The charge is that the evidentialist criterion cannot satisfy itself.

The argument. Clifford requires sufficient evidence for every belief; Flew adds the presumption of atheism, making non-belief the rational default. Plantinga replies that the objection presupposes **classical foundationalism** - a belief is rational only if self-evident, incorrigible, evident to the senses, or inferred from such beliefs. That criterion is (i) **self-referentially incoherent**, since it is itself none of those things and is not derivable from them; and (ii) **too narrow**, since memory beliefs, beliefs in other minds and beliefs about the past are plainly rational without meeting it. If basicity is not confined to the classical list, theistic belief formed in appropriate circumstances may be properly basic.

How far the charge succeeds. It succeeds against *classical* foundationalism. It does not defeat every evidentialism: a more modest version - proportion your confidence to your total evidence, whatever counts as evidence - does not obviously self-destruct, and James's own reply is confined to living, forced and momentous options.

The residue. The Great Pumpkin objection presses that anything could then be basic. Plantinga answers with grounding, defeasibility and disciplined practice; critics note this makes the criterion community-relative and readmits well-established rival traditions.

Verdict: the self-defeat charge is decisive against the strict criterion and inconclusive against evidentialism as such. Its real achievement is to shift the burden - the evidentialist must now state a standard that religion fails and memory passes. The defeater would be exactly such a standard, stated and defended.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question. "Reason may audit revelation, but it cannot author it." Critically examine this claim with reference to both Western and Indian positions.

Model answer. The claim asserts an asymmetry between two powers: assessment and production. It is defensible, and its defence is the strongest general account of this clause.

The audit. Reason performs four religious functions - constructing natural theology, testing coherence, interpreting text, and defending or criticising. To these must be added the fifth, **regulation**: vetoing contradiction, weighing testimony, disciplining reading and naming defeaters. Regulation is negative and occasion-bound. Construction of religious *content*, by contrast, would be constitutive.

The Western settlement. Aquinas embodies the asymmetry. Reason establishes the preambles; revelation supplies the mysteries, which are above reason and never against it; and since both routes issue from God, an apparent conflict signals defective reasoning or interpretation. Faith is the intellect's firm assent, commanded by the will under grace, with the motives of credibility as the hinge that keeps it from voluntarism. Kierkegaard attacks a different target - the substitution of a system for appropriation - and so does not contradict the asymmetry; he presses it. Hick radicalises it: an event is religiously ambiguous, and faith's "experiencing-as" supplies the religious reading that reason cannot generate.

The Indian settlement. Advaita gives the asymmetry a pedagogy: scripture (*śruti*) discloses, reasoning (*manana*) removes doubt, and dialectical reasoning (*tarka*) is auxiliary and never independently probative. Mīmāṃsā radicalises the authority side, holding the Veda authorless and so requiring no revealer and no miraculous authentication; reason

interprets injunction but does not produce it. Nyāya, by contrast, treats the word of a reliable authority (*āpta-vākya*) as a means of knowledge whose credibility must be established, and its extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) is the closest classical analogue of evidentialism.

Objections. First, a power of universal veto amounts to sovereignty. *Reply:* a referee who disallows a goal has not scored it; refusing and generating are different acts. Second, if reason interprets, it partly constitutes the content it claims only to audit. *Reply:* this is the strongest objection, and the honest concession is that interpretation is a *shared* function, which is why hermeneutics is contested territory rather than reason's private domain. Third, the circle: scripture authenticates the authority that authenticates scripture. *Reply:* the circle is vicious only where it is the sole support, and independent testimony, coherence, moral fruit and cross-tradition comparison break the closure.

Verdict. Reason audits and does not author - but the boundary is porous exactly at interpretation, and that is where the interesting disputes in both traditions actually occur. The claim would be defeated by a demonstration that no religious content survives once interpretation is subtracted; nothing in either tradition currently supplies that demonstration.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question. Evaluate the view that the problem of religious diversity, rather than the problem of evidence, is the decisive obstacle to justified religious belief.

Model answer. The view proposes a reordering of the standard objections. It is largely correct, but only after the evidential objection has been properly answered.

Stage one: the evidential objection and its answer. Evidentialism demands that assent be proportioned to evidence - Locke on probability, Clifford's moral maxim of 1877, Flew's presumption of atheism. James restricts the demand: for a living, forced and momentous option where evidence cannot decide, the passional nature may lawfully choose, and Clifford's rule itself encodes a preference for avoiding error over gaining truth. Plantinga goes further: the objection presupposes classical foundationalism, which is self-referentially incoherent and cannot accommodate memory, other minds or beliefs about the past; belief in God formed in the right circumstances may be properly basic, grounded, warranted by proper function and defeasible. Alston adds that no doxastic practice, sense perception included, is non-circularly validated.

Stage two: what the answer costs. Each of these replies relocates justification *inside* a practice. Warrant now depends on faculties functioning properly in an appropriate environment, or on participation in a socially established practice. That is a real defence, but it is available to any sufficiently mature tradition.

Stage three: why diversity becomes decisive. The Great Pumpkin objection is answered by grounding and defeasibility; the "Son of Great Pumpkin" version is not, because well-established rival traditions do have grounding, discipline and internal defeater-management. In revelation-authentication the same pattern appears: the six criteria - testimony, coherence, moral fruit, tradition, sign, comparison - are all defeasible and, critically, **none is neutral between traditions**. Rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims; distinguishing core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation answers this, but the move is revisionary by the tradition's own standards.

Indian control. The Indian bench shows the difficulty is structural rather than parochial. Intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) grants a cognition validity until defeated - which is exactly what a rival tradition also claims for its own. The authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda removes the revealer, and so removes one comparative test without supplying another.

Objection. Diversity is a defeater to be answered, not an automatic refutation; and a tradition may hold that its own account explains the others. **Reply.** True, and no one holds diversity is easily answered. But an explanation of rivals offered from inside a practice is precisely what a rival can also offer.

Verdict. The view is correct in its ordering. Once justification is located inside a doxastic practice, evidential insufficiency ceases to be the live problem and incompatible practices take its place. The defeater would be a tradition-neutral criterion that discriminates among mature practices; the absence of such a criterion, rather than any shortage of evidence, is what makes diversity decisive.